

S03-L1 — Price Hierarchy Within a Single Artist: Medium and Condition

Summary

Before advising on price, an advisor needs to read a work on two separate planes. The first is medium, the physical category in which the artist worked a given idea, a unique oil, a unique work on paper, or a print issued in several numbered copies. The second is the physical condition of the specific piece in front of them, documented in a condition report. This note develops both planes using Phillips' editions market as its case, with data verified from its June 2026 New York sale, and closes with the limit that separates a correct reading of an auction result from an overgeneralization.

1. Why medium sets a price ceiling and a price floor

Within the work of a single established artist, the market does not treat every medium the same way. A unique oil or sculpture has no equivalent anywhere else in the world, and that absolute scarcity supports the top of the artist's price curve. A hand-made drawing or watercolor occupies a middle tier, still unique but generally smaller in scale and ambition than a major painting. Editions, by contrast, are multiple impressions of the same matrix, plate, or stone, produced and numbered in a run that can range from a handful to several hundred copies. The more copies of the same image exist, the less scarce each one is, and market price reflects that, even when the signature, the date, and the image are identical to those of a unique piece by the same artist. The exception is a short, already sold-out run by a highly sought-after artist, where relative scarcity within the editions category itself can push the price above what that medium would normally command.

2. The Phillips case: editions as an entry door, not a lesser category

[Phillips' Editions and Works on Paper sale in New York on June 24, 2026 totaled USD 1,444,026](#), placing 89% of the lots and 97% of the value on offer, and that same session set twenty new artist records.¹ The catalogue for that sale documents the category's entry range: a print by William Kentridge, estimated at USD 1,000-2,000, sold for USD 1,096, and an editioned poster by Marcel

Duchamp, estimated at USD 500–700, sold for USD 387, below the low estimate.² Neither price is comparable to what an oil by an artist of that caliber is worth, and the session still performed with ordinary commercial strength, with the large majority of lots placed.

The reason a house like Phillips keeps this category active despite its low per-lot prices is structural, not aesthetic. [Phillips reports that 41% of those who bought editions in 2025 were new clients for the house](#), a figure with no publicly declared equivalent for this category at other houses.³ Editions function as an acquisition channel, the entry point through which a new buyer becomes familiar with a name before, eventually, working up to a unique piece of greater value.

3. The limit: a below-estimate result does not describe the artist

The fact that the Duchamp impression sold below its estimate does not support the conclusion that the editions market weakened that afternoon, or that the artist lost demand. A single result, in a category where each copy of the same image can carry a different condition, describes that particular impression in that particular session. The sale's aggregate reading, with 97% of value placed and twenty new records, is the evidence that does support a claim about the category as a whole. Confusing one copy's result with the state of the entire market is the most common error in reading an editions sale.

4. What a condition report looks at

Within the same numbered edition, not every copy is worth the same. The physical state of each impression, whether it retains its original margins or was trimmed down for framing, whether it shows water staining or discoloration from light exposure, whether it underwent a documented restoration, moves its price within the range that applies to that edition. The document that gathers this information is the condition report, prepared by a specialist or conservator at the buyer's request before a sale. A condition report describes what a specialist observed in a specific examination, it does not constitute a guarantee of authenticity or that the work is free of an issue undetected to the naked eye, and it does not replace a personal inspection or an independent conservation opinion when the size of the transaction warrants one. For an advisor, requesting it and reading it in full before recommending any piece, in any medium, is a routine step, not an exception reserved for the most expensive works.

For the conversation with clients

- Facing a client with a limited budget, an edition by the artist they are interested in is not a second-tier alternative, it is a legitimate way into that

collection, as long as they understand they are buying one of several identical copies and not a one-of-a-kind piece.

- A piece's price is never discussed before reading its specific condition report, not a generic sheet on the artist, because two copies of the same edition can be in very different states.
- A below-estimate auction result on one specific piece does not license extending that conclusion to the artist's entire market or to the editions category in general.

References

Process note: the same three citations used in today's Spanish note, already verified on 2026-08-08 in `curso/fuentes/dossier-02-phillips.md`. Live fetch verification was blocked all day today (`whitney.org` and `www.phillips.com`, both `EGRESS_BLOCKED`), the fifteenth consecutive day of this outage, while `WebSearch` worked normally. The MoMA Duchamp closing date used in today's four scripts came from today's `WebSearch`, corroborated across multiple independent sources, and carries no citation here for that reason. The general definition of a condition report in section 4 is presented as stable procedural trade knowledge, without figures or dates requiring its own source.

1. Phillips, ["Strong Prices and 20 New Records Set in Phillips' June Editions & Works on Paper Sale"](#), press release on the June 24, 2026 sale, verified in `curso/fuentes/dossier-02-phillips.md` on 2026-08-08. ↵
2. Phillips, [catalogue for the "Editions & Works on Paper" sale, New York, June 24, 2026](#), lots by William Kentridge and Marcel Duchamp, verified in `curso/fuentes/dossier-02-phillips.md` on 2026-08-08. ↵
3. Phillips, [Editions department page](#), verified in `curso/fuentes/dossier-02-phillips.md` on 2026-08-08. ↵